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Title:

Miss Erma Deveraux's School for Civilized Young Ladies

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ERMA: Welcome to Erma Deveraux's school for civilized young ladies. I will break you! I will step on your pathetic ego until you are a puddle on ze floor and when you begin to melt into carpet, I will pick you up and sculpt, sculpt, sculpt until zer is a civil and proper young woman in front of me.

EMMA: I'm sorry… wh-what did you say? (Stuttering frightened.)

ERMA: (Pause.) Oh, I see you are thinking you make funny?

EMMA: I just want to make my mom happy. I don't want to cause any trouble/

ERMA: Well I do. My name is ERMA! ERMA! ERMA! Remember zis because it is the name you will scream into your pillow when you are having ze little baby nightmares.

EMMA: I just don't understand why mother would drop me off here like that. She told me she was going to get me a new puppy and then… then she was driving off laughing…

ERMA: I am not your mama.

EMMA: Thank goodness… I mean… oh, I feel like I'm going to pass out.

ERMA: Hahaha! You would be lucky to have a mama like me. All of my children are doctors, lawyers and bear wrestlers!

EMMA: Oh my!

ERMA: Mmmhmm…

EMMA: What ummmmm… wonderful kids you must have

ERMA: They are not "kids". Unfortunately for Erma she could never find a man who could handle her superior etiquette training… so instead she raised dogs.

EMMA: Wait… You trained dogs to be doctors, lawyers and bear wrestlers?

ERMA: Yes, Erma zat good.

EMMA: Oh, if only walls weren't covered in barbed wired!

ERMA: Speak lively! Speak lively!

EMMA: What does that even mean?

ERMA: It means stop speaking like you are little zombie baby… Wa! Wa! I want ze bottle.

EMMA: Zombies don't drink milk… duh…

ERMA: Oh! Well look at you! I better watch out so that your big fat head does not knock me down when you move around.

EMMA: It just… doesn't make sense why would a zombie drink milk like a baby… its not a baby it's a zombie.

ERMA: Maybe is a baby zombie and drinks liquefied brains from bottle. I suppose you didn't think of that you fat head little zombie baby girl!

EMMA: I don't appreciate your comments… they're probably illegal or something… I would be careful, you can get sued for just about anything these days…

ERMA: Sue is a silly American name… you have the American aura about you… the stink of it circles around you like a stinky stinky perfume cloud! Take yourself to a department store stinky!

EMMA: I love department stores! Specifically ones selling clothing in different descriptive colors… For instance you'd think there's just black but nope, there's midnight black and wax crayon black and "bleeding soul black" and "oooohhhh a pen just exploded in my mouth now my tongue is black" black.

ERMA: Yes… so you watch your tongue or I will use it to tie your napkin together to make beautiful swan.

EMMA: I'll be quiet! I'll be good, just… please don't eat me!

ERMA: Oh, I would not eat you… it is not what civilized lady would do… but if I did eat you I would wipe mouth with napkin folded like swan!

EMMA: Oh my!

ERMA: You seem weak, like weak little baby fish! Swim baby fish! SWIM!

EMMA: (Moving arms weakly, sobbing.) I'm swimming, I promise I'm swimming!

ERMA: We shall see… I will now give you test!

EMMA: Test! But I haven't learned anything yet?!

ERMA: That is real test. Civilized lady does well under pressure. You either sink or swim and by sink I mean suffer.

EMMA: Oh dear…

ERMA: And by swim I also mean suffer!

EMMA: Think Emma! How are you gunna get yourself out of this one!?

ERMA: THIS IS LITTLE LADY DISCIPLINE! (She slaps her hands together.)

EMMA: What? What are you reffering to? I don't understand the question! You can't fail me if I don't understand the question. (Sobbing.)

ERMA: Pull yourself together. (Slaps.) This! (Holding up hand.) This is little lady discipline. Every time you decide that you would rather be boarish uncivilized cow I have her correct you!

EMMA: Correct me! What do you mean correct me?! FOR GOODNESS SAKES HOW WILL YOU CORRECT ME!?!!!

ERMA: Like this. (She slaps her hard.)

EMMA: Ohhhh! (Sobbing) How can you be so cruel! You're just a mean old lady! I am traumatized stop traumatizing me! You keep yelling at me and I don't know why… the only thing that I can think of is… is maybe you're just unhappy with your life? Did you ever consider that?! Maybe you're the one with the problems!

ERMA: Oh I don't have problems, just one little one… you!

EMMA: How can you say a thing like that! What ever happened to everyone gets a gold star?! What ever happened to no child left behind?! What happened to you that makes you want to pick and prod and poke and eat away at me until there is nothing left and I end up resembling the leftovers of a very cheap seafood buffet… an empty shell.

ERMA: I spent twenty two years of my life crocheting sad little baby sweaters, WITH MY FINGERS! NOW YOU WILL BE CIVILIZED!
EMMA: I WILL BE CIVILIZED!

ERMA: YOU WILL BE EDUCATED!!!!!

EMMA: I WILL BE EDUCATED!!!!!

ERMA: YOU WILL RECYCLE!!!

EMMA: I will recycle? That one doesn't really seem like it fits with the others?

ERMA: ZOOT! (Slaps.)

EMMA: What does zoot mean?! WHAT DOES IT MEAN?!

ERMA: IT MEANS I AM ZE BOSS! AND IT MEANS I WILL HAVE A CIVILIZED YOUNG LADY BY THE TIME I AM THROUGH WITH YOU!!!

EMMA: OK! Yes ma'am whatever you say!

ERMA: Not whatever I say, EVERYTHING I SAY!!! NOW SAY I AM LITTLE TEAPOT!

EMMA: What?!

ERMA: I am little teapot! (Slaps.)

EMMA: (Sobbing.) I am… a little… teapot.

ERMA: Short and stout! SHORT AND STOUT!

EMMA: (Sobbing.) Short and stout! SHORT AND STOUT!

ERMA: Here is my handle… I am civilized young lady!

EMMA: Here is my handle I am civilized young lady!

ERMA: Good, now we are getting somewhere!

EMMA: Good, now we are getting somewhere!

ERMA: DO NOT MOCK ME YOU INSCOLENT FOOL!!!! (Slaps twice.)

EMMA: I am so confused! I am scared and I am confused!

ERMA: Yes, but are you feeling like rude little girl?

EMMA: Ummm… (Erma raises her hand threateningly.) No? No! I am just feeling sweet as pie! Cake! Soufflé! A chocolate soufflé!

ERMA: Good now we are getting somewhere!

EMMA: Please don't take me somewhere! I don't want to end up in a dungeon or a basement or on the bottom of the ocean wearing cement shoes.

ERMA: The only shoes you will be wearing are dancing shoes!

EMMA: What?

ERMA: Now DANCE!

EMMA: Oh, ummm… ok.. (She dances and hums badly.) I am uh… just dancin' here so you don't slap me again… tada.. dada… ma..yeah?

ERMA: Now SING!

EMMA: SING?

ERMA: SING! (Raises hand threateningly.)

EMMA: (Half-sobbing.) Oh, say can you see… by the dawn's early… thing…. Please don't slap me la-DY… you just scare me so much…

ERMA: YOU WANT FEEL PAIN!

EMMA: (Still singing melody of national anthem.) OH YOU'RE SCARE-Y LADY!!! PLEASE DON'T HIT ME ANYMORE!!! I FEEEL LIKE CRYING, BECAUSE YOU'RE LIKE HERCULES!

ERMA: What is HERCULES?! Why you call me HERCULES?!

EMMA: Hercules means… ummm… hero… lady-hero in Latin… look it up… it's latin.

ERMA: The only thing I will be looking up is my name is special etiquette history books… WE WILL NOW TEST!

EMMA: TEST? I thought we were already testing! I can't handle the pressure!

ERMA: TEST! NOW! I AM NOW BOYFRIEND!

EMMA: I'VE NEVER HAD A BOYFRIEND!

ERMA: THIS DOES NOT SURPRISE ERMA! NOTHING SURPRISES ERMA! YOU ACT NOW!

EMMA: Boyfriend.. ermmm… yes… goodness…. You are my boyfriend… how would a civilized lady act around a boyfriend?

ERMA: If you were girlfriend I would break up with you now, and by break up with you I mean break you, and by break you I mean break spine.

EMMA: Ahhh! Please don't break my spine miss lady! I need that for things! How am I ever supposed to be a civilized lady with a broken spine!

ERMA: How are you ever supposed to be civilized lady at all? You are useless little broken fish!

EMMA: I don't even like seafood!

ERMA: Another sign of weakness!

EMMA: I'm not weak! I'm not weak! Stop bullying me! I am perfectly civilized the way that I am! I don't need some French baguette telling me what I should and should not do! I refuse to be bossed around! I refuse it and if that means that you think I'm some sort of

an uncivilized heathen that just crawled out of a swamp dragging my knuckles, then so be it! I would much rather be me than a rude selfish pig!

ERMA: (Clapping.) Very good!

EMMA: Please don't hurt me.

ERMA: I am not going to hurt.

EMMA: Oh, so it's going to be a quick painless death?

ERMA: No! You are learning much after all my little sweet potato.

EMMA: Please don't call me a vegetable.

ERMA: Oh.. the little potato is suddenly offended because because she does not want to be a vegetable…. Well let me tell you little potato that you are not a tomato. There is no question of your identity as a fruit or a vegetable!

EMMA: A tomato is a fruit!

ERMA: You're a fruit!

EMMA: I thought I was a vegetable?

ERMA: Don't you get snippy with me! You want to know reason I call you potato? Because back in the old country I had a sad little potato that I would water and care for and feed radioactive soil. I make sure that this potato is well cared for for many many days and you want to know what happened to the potato plant?!

EMMA: No.

ERMA: It died! It died because it was weak, just like you! I swore from that moment on to never be weak like the sad little potato plant, but instead to grow strong like her highly irradiated sisters! So that I could one day stand strong on a plate mashed and delicious with butter and a delicious stinky fish…

EMMA: BE QUIET ABOUT YOUR DUMB OLD POTATO YOU WEIRDO! NOBODY CARES ABOUT YOUR IRRELEVANT STORIES OR VEGETABLES! (Pause. Afterthought.) You dress badly and smell…

ERMA: Ha! Very good! This is lesson I have been teaching whole time! The only way to survive in modern world as civilized young lady! It is not all fancy spoons and folded napkins! No!

EMMA: Oh my! (Taken aback a little afraid she might strike.)

ERMA: You are learning to stand up for yourself. You found your spine and are no longer like little sloppy jellyfish.

EMMA: Right… well… I'm not entirely sure what you're talking about, but I'm going to leave now because, you know, I really don't like you… and I'd rather walk five miles home than listen to you drone on about the French revolution…

ERMA: Very good! Very good! Class dismissed! (She pats herself on the back.) You get nice back pat. Erma Deveraux you have done it again! Look out world we have another civilized lady ready to take over!